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Prompt: What do we gain and what do we lose when machines “read” literature for us?
How do Voyant and GPT imagine “meaning” differently?

I chose to use *Pride and Prejudice*, a novel by Jane Austen, to analyze for this assignment.

I ran an analysis on Voyant Tools, which is a software designed to identify the most frequently used words of a text and allow you to categorize and sort them in many ways. What I noticed about Voyant’s analysis was that it was primarily to understand the statistics, such as how many times in a story a certain word would come up. This was a literal count of how many times the word was there, which is visible without much analysis. In *Pride and Prejudice*, some of the most common words mentioned throughout the story were “Mr.,” “Elizabeth,” “Darcy,” “Said,” and “Mrs.,” all of which are understandable because they are the names of the main characters (Elizabeth Bennet and Mr. Darcy), and “Mr.” and “Mrs.” are used frequently throughout the story to refer to people. Something else I enjoyed about Voyant is how it makes a word cloud of all of the words, with the most used words appearing the largest. This was a nice way to represent the frequency of words used. Additionally, there is a line-by-line breakdown of all of the words, and a table with values. This was all useful for identifying these components of the text. While Voyant tools was useful for this kind of understanding, it requires the person to make the observations and string together meaning rather than the machine. Voyant does not identify themes or meaning, but rather picks up on the way things are organized in the text.

On ChatGPT, however, there is much more analysis and theme-based work. I wrote “What is *Pride and Prejudice* about?” and it gave me a large summary about what the book is like, what the characters are like, and main themes of the story. Rather than telling me about the way the text appears, it had paragraphs of summary about the character arcs, as well as a list of themes. Something else I noticed was that it included an analysis of why it is such a popular story. These are all explanations.

In summary, both of these tools can be used to better understand a text, but at the end of the day, the work you do with the text yourself is more important to understanding the text.

Acknowledgement:

Text used (title, author, source)

Pride and Prejudice by Jane Austen.

The full text of this book is available at: <https://www.gutenberg.org/files/1342/1342-0.txt>

Tools used

Voyant Tools

ChatGPT

GPT prompt(s)

"What is *Pride and Prejudice* about?"

What each tool could *not* do

Voyant tools only told me about the number of times a word was used, but nothing about the meaning.

ChatGPT did the opposite, as it told me about the themes but did not provide statistical analysis.